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How Do Influencers Affect the Buying Behavior of Females in KSA

By

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Thesis Advisor: Dr Zainah Qasem

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Declaration of Authenticity

I Tala Harb declare that all of the materials presented in this paper are my work, or fully and specifically acknowledged wherever adapted from other sources. I understand that if at any time it is shown that I have significantly misrepresented material presented to Effat College of Business at Effat University, any degree or credits awarded to me based on that material may be revoked.

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Abstract

The purpose of this study is to explore social media influencers influence on women in Saudi Arabia. Increasingly more companies employ the capacities of influencer marketing. It allows brands to reach their audience in a new way especially due to the fact that modern Saudi women are fairly active on such social platforms as, for example, Instagram, Snapchat, Twitter, and others. Western researchers have conducted numerous studies on influencer marketings well as uncovered its logics and peculiarities however, the subtleties and effectiveness of this strategy in the Middle Eastern countries are still underinvestigated. This research aims to close this gap by analyzing how social media influencers impact female consumers in Saudi Arabia influencing impulse purchases.

In Saudi Arabia, it is important to understand how influencers influence women's purchases. First, influencers are important to influence the preferences and purchasing decisions of Saudi Arabian female consumers due to their increasing digitization. Furthermore, examining the ways influentials navigate this terrain by considering the unique cultural context of Saudi Arabia, the results of this research at home and abroad can contribute to further discussion of Middle Eastern consumer culture beyond substantial Companies affected would.

This study relies on a quantitative methodology and questionnaires to pinpoint the subconscious traits responsible for motivating the influencer-consumer interaction in the Saudi market. The examination of SMIs can lead to a better grip of the marketing dynamics involved due to the understanding of factors such as their behavior or usage of cultural contexts and as well as the motives for their collaboration with companies and the perception and trait of authenticity.

Acknowledgements

I am deeply grateful to the people who have guided me for the duration of the adventure of penning this research. First and fundamental, I amplify my heartfelt appreciation to my manager Dr Zainah Qasem, for her useful steering and unwavering guide. Her encouragement and understanding have been crucial in determining the path of this artwork. In addition, I extend my gratitude to Effat University for providing the centers and vital resources needed to complete these studies. Not to mention, I owe a huge debt of gratitude to my own family for their unfailing support, knowledge, and patience during this endeavor. I have gotten my energy from their love and support. I express my sincere gratitude to everyone who has helped with this article in any way, whether directly or indirectly.

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How do influencers affect the buying behavior of females in KSA

1. Introduction

Influencers on social media have therefore grown to be an effective marketing tool. Depending on the content and message structure, certain influencers in Saudi Arabia are the most useful for fostering social selling and boosting online sales. As a result, the purpose of this study was to assess how social media influencers affect consumers' opinions on what to buy. This study research question is How do influencers affect the buying behavior of females in KSA, and it is focused on the potential influence of celebrities and online influencers on the purchasing decisions of Saudi Arabian consumers. The objective of this research is to know the role of influencers and their affect on the impulse buying on online customers

Recently, with the development of mobile devices such as the internet, tablets and smartphones, the popularity of social media has increased remarkably the connectivity in these areas was also greatly impacted by the availability of easy WI-FI. These instruments have grown in popularity in recent years, and their features have changed accordingly. In fact, companies have been able to thrive and use this huge popularity to capture and accomplish their goals. For an international business or e-merchant to be found online these days, it needs to be active on social media.

Marketing in recent years has become a completely different field against the background of the rise of social media, as well as the appearance of influencer marketing, which represents a new direction for interacting with the audience for many brands. Social media platforms have changed the situation making various advertising and promotional campaigns possible. In the community of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, where traditional marketing channels dominated before, social networks are a new opportunity for companies to reach their target audience and especially the female part.

Understanding the impact of influencers is of big importance to track how it affects the buying behavior of females in KSA. This research paper will get into the details of influencer marketing in the Saudi market exploring how the social intermediate powers work, the mechanism by which it influence consumer perception, and finally, the extent to which it influences their purchase. This paper will utilize a holistic strategy, combining the primary data, secondary data, the quantitative research instrument, and sample size to achieve this goal.

By conducting the surveys and analyzing the gathered data, we want to reveal the unconscious variables and factors that determine the influencer mechanism and interaction in the Saudi Market. Even though influencer marketing has been well-researched in the West, there is limited understanding of its effectiveness in the eastern areas including the Middle East. Especially on how it affects female customers under a conservative lifestyle like the Saudi Arabian society. Consequently, by addressing this gap in the existing body of knowledge, this work broadens the scope and enlightens the current knowledge of the consumer-influencer relationship.

2. Literature Review:

2.1 Role of Social Media Influencers

Social media influencers (SMIs) have a big impact on Saudi Arabian women's purchasing decisions (Alalwan et al., 2020). According to Al-Debei et al. (2019), influencers use popular platforms like Instagram, Snapchat, Tiktok, and Twitter to present lifestyles that appeal to their followers, especially young girls. Influencers are portrayed in this way as trend-setters and role models who affect the tastes and purchasing decisions of their followers.

Through positive advertising, SMIs prompt their followers to acquire products such as clothes, make up, and video games. In addition, SMIs can influence their followers to endorse new behaviours and routines outside of what they are used to (Albeshry et al., 2024). This suggests that SMIs have the ability not only to change their viewers' buying habits, but also their overall behaviors such as characteristics, routine, and lifestyle choices.

2.2 Cultural Context and Influencer Impact

The impact of influencers on female customers is enhanced by the cultural environment of Saudi Arabia (Algharabat et al., 2021). Influencers serve as a link between brands and customers in a conservative environment where traditional advertising is minimal (Alshurideh et al., 2022). By incorporating cultural values and traditions into the content they create, they improve their audience engagement and believability. Regardless of the extent of how SMIs can influence their followers, it was shown that other social factors can influence young Saudi females as well, such as family, culture, religion and social norms. One of the reasons that causes such factors to have effect on the consumer's behavior is the fact that Saudi Arabia is shifting towards a knowledge-based economy rather than oil-based. This has led to the opening of multiple major

shopping malls and centers, to keep pace with the Kingdom's goals of Vision 2030 (Algumzi et al., 2022). This has led people to go out more often, which in result leads to people purchasing more often. Previously, people in Saudi Arabia typically cooked and ate at home or at a friend's house, and dining out in a restaurant was somewhat frowned upon. But during the last decade, foodservice restaurants grew more popular (Leung et al., 2022).

2.3 Authenticity and Relatability

Influencers' capability to connect with their audience and to be honest with them has a big impact on how much buying behavior they can affect (Ghaziri & Bahaa, 2017). Saudi Arabian women shoppers regard endorsements from influencers as authentic and reliable (Al-Hamarneh et al., 2018). Because of their trust, people are more likely to try the goods or services that these influencers recommend. However, SMIs do not always promote products truthfully which causes people to lose trust in them, but even then promoting through SMIs is still viewed as more effective than advertising campaigns because consumers usually perceive them as more trustworthy (Mabkhot et al., 2022).

2.4 Collaborative Efforts with Brands

Brands and influencers working together further shapes consumers' purchasing decisions (Alalwan et al., 2020). Product placements, brand collaborations, and sponsored content give female customers a sense of validation and acceptance that influences their purchase decisions (Al-Debei et al., 2019). It is known that SMIs are professionals in social media advertising, which results in organizations and brands who are interested in marketing their products on social media to seek them out as it is cheaper than launching advertising campaigns (Mabkhot et al., 2022).

2.5 Factors Influencing Influencer Impact

Influencer credibility, product relevance, and amount of follower engagement are some of the main variables that affect how influencers affect consumers' purchasing decisions (Alshurideh et al., 2022). These factors determine whether influencer marketing efforts work in Saudi Arabia's market.

Social media influencers (SMIs) have a great effect on the consumer's buying behavior in Saudi Arabia. The influence has especially increased during the Covid-19 pandemic due to lockdown, which has caused many people to switch to online shopping. This has boosted the importance of SMIs in the past few years. However, credibility is a vital factor when it comes to influencing a consumer's buying habits. Sometimes SMIs can advertise an inadequate product claiming that it is of quality, only for the consumer to discover that it is poor. This can cause the consumer to feel cheated, which can affect the influence SMIs have on their viewers (Mabkhot et al., 2022).

3. Methodology:

This part of the research paper discusses the methodology which is the tools used in order to develop our research and how we collected information in order to complete the research. It includes the primary data, secondary data, quantitative research tool, and sample size. Each part is explained in detail on how we managed to gather and collect the information we needed.

3.1 Secondary Data

This research paper includes both primary and secondary data. Secondary data is information based on already existing data. Secondary data has already been discussed and evaluated in the literature review. Secondary data has been gathered from scholarly articles, books, and trade publications. All information gathered is valid and reliable. It discusses how social media influencers can affect the purchasing behavior of females depending on their role, culture, the extent in which customers relate to influencers, and influencers collaboration with brands. Moreover, it discusses how customers started trusting influencers more after the Covid-19 pandemic since everything and everyone switched online. Secondary data information has been gathered and analyzed through deep research from already existing data that is accredited by professional researchers and is 100% valid and reliable.

3.2 Primary Data

In addition, this research paper includes primary data as well. Primary data is information gathered by researchers themselves in order to complete their research findings. Primary data will be conducted and gathered by sharing a survey among Saudi citizens. The survey includes all aspects of our research, asking citizens, specifically Saudi females about how social media influencers can affect their purchasing behavior. The survey includes close-ended and open-

ended questions that cover all important topics and problems of our research to help us gain more knowledge and all the information we need regarding how influencers have a huge impact in today's world. The survey will be distributed among Saudi citizens, their response will be analyzed and evaluated as well.

3.3 Quantitative Research

This research is based on quantitative data. Quantitative methods are responsible for data that can be counted or measured in numerical values. It is a type of study methodology that centers on gathering and evaluating measurable data in order to form inferences and forecasts. It entails the analysis of data using statistical and mathematical techniques. The data are often gathered through experiments, structured surveys, and research questions. Our research is quantitative research since it aims to measure and quantify variables, relationships, and patterns in the data. It frequently uses huge sample sizes which will help us gain knowledge and information on our research problem. The impact of influencers on customers purchasing behavior is all based on numerical values that are gathered from our survey. Our quantitative research aims to gather numerical information about customers' level of trust and loyalty towards influencers.

3.4 Sample Size

To ensure that our study on how social media influencers affect females purchasing behavior is reliable and provides a comprehensive understanding, we need to carefully determine the right number of individuals to include in our research. By employing a quantitative approach to measure prevalence, test hypotheses, and establish causal relationships between variables, we need a sufficiently large group of participants. Our main focus will be on individual females who use social media and shops often because we think their experiences will give us important information. Our goal is to include around 50 females from different cities in Saudi Arabia with

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different perspectives. This will help us understand the topic better. To make sure our group of individuals represents everyone well, we will use a method called convenience sampling. It's essential to note that, while we had alternative sampling methods at our disposal, we deliberately chose convenience sampling for specific reasons. This method permits us to select participants based on their accessibility and availability. In essence, it empowers us to gather dependable and credible data concerning our topic as it is cheap, efficient, and simple to implement. We have exercised meticulous care in the selection process, aiming to elevate both the validity and reliability of our study's findings. This means we will consider things like where the individuals come from, which social media platform they use the most, and their personal information when choosing who to include. By being careful in how we choose our individuals, we hope to gather strong and trustworthy information about the impact of influencers on females purchasing behavior.

4. Results:

This section presents descriptive statistics which include several questions from the survey in order to understand and gather information from female consumers in relation to influencers. The number of responses was 50 coming only from females in order to carry out this research in the right way.

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

What age group do you belong to
50 responses

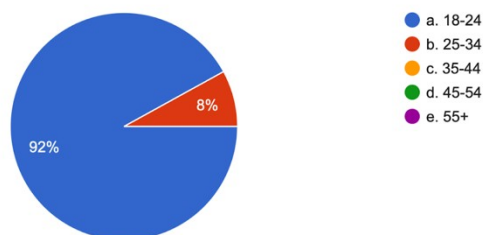


Figure 1. Responders age

Figure 1 shows 92% of the respondents' ages ranged from 18-24, since this is the average age of consumers are influenced more by purchasing or following influencers on different platforms. That age was mostly reached according to the questionnaire. We did not ask about gender because this research is aimed directly at females.

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What is your marital status
50 responses

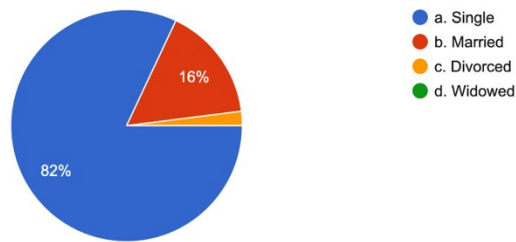


Figure 2. Responders status

Figure 2 provides the state of marital status confirms valuable insights into the demographic information that can be used in market segmentation. The higher percentage of females were single with an 82%, and 18% of the respondents are married which indicates a notable demographic trend along the sample population.

In which region of Saudi Arabia do you reside
50 responses

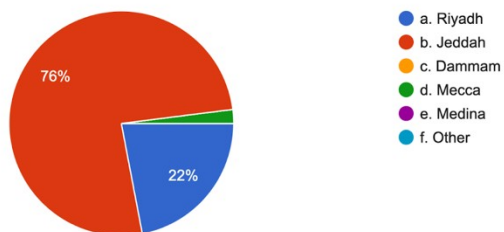


Figure 3. Responders Residence

Figure 3 shows the region is KSA and it is related to track down which city holds the most interaction regarding the geographical locations and diversity. It focused on two highest-impact cities: Jeddah and Riyadh. Jeddah has the highest percentage which attracts significant investment and business activities, as well as Riyadh which is the commercial hub in KSA.

Which social media platform(s) do you use the most

51 responses

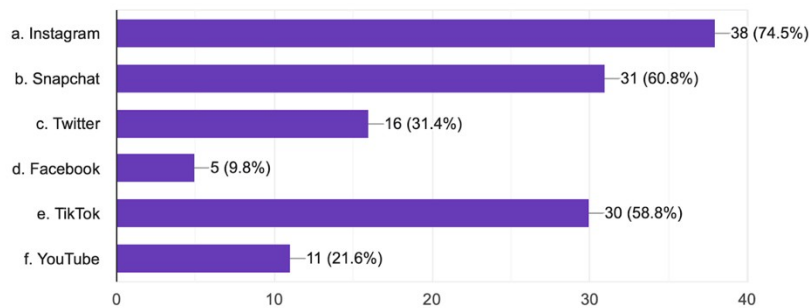


Figure 4. Most used platform

Figure 4 allows us to understand as marketers carrying this research, which platform is used by the consumers and where does the influencing on buying behaviors lie. In the graph, instagram has the highest interaction with 74.5%, next comes snapchat with 60.8% and close to it is Tiktok. Those platforms are indeed the most used by females for entertaining and buying purposes. That's why influencers focus mainly on those 3 platforms to carry out their advertisements or how they show products and goods to the viewer.

Do you follow any influencers on social media

50 responses

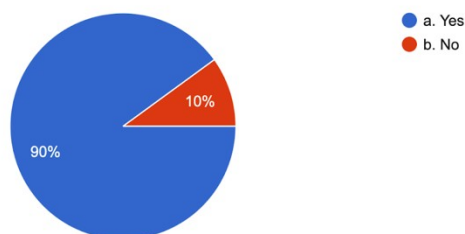


Figure 5. Following influencers percentage result

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Figure 5 shows a “yes” or “no” question to generally know if females follow influencers and browse or they don’t. 90% of the answers were a yes, showing the widespread influence of social media relation within this demographic. Conversely, only 10% of the respondents were a no indicating they don’t follow influencers, which suggests a minority within the population who don’t engage with influencer content.

If yes, how many influencers do you follow on a regular basis
51 responses

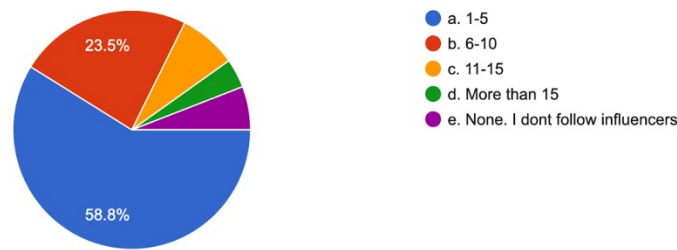


Figure 6. Number of followed influencers

Figure 6 was related to the previous one in regard to the individuals who put “yes” as an option to following influencers on social media platforms. The purpose of this question is having a bigger view of the number of influencers that females follow. The answers ranged according to the different perspectives and interests of the following influencers. Near 60% follow from 1-5, and 23.5% follow 6-10. People who follow many influencers have a low percentage of respondents where they are interested with the lifestyle of a more diverse and bigger platform to look at.

What products or services do the influencers you follow usually promote
50 responses

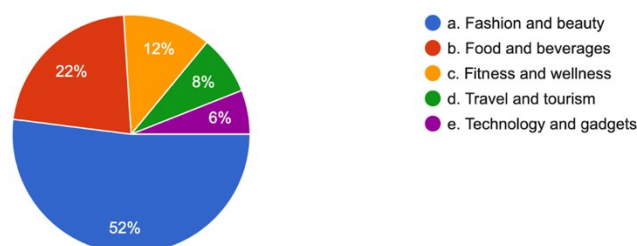


Figure 7. Preferred products percentage result

Figure 7 shows how it's important to know what consumers search for the most when they follow influencers, or what interests them and affects their buying behavior. Every person has their own likings and preferences when it comes to purchasing a product, that's why knowing which product or service are promoted mostly by influencers and liked by the individuals. Because this questionnaire targeted females only, the higher percentage was 52%, for fashion and beauty. Since they care so much about their physical appearance and makeup, beauty influencers really impact the buying behavior. After beauty and fashion, food and beverages are also of priority because it's an interesting field to look at and observe what a specific restaurant offers from food or influencers themselves being a big impact when they review those restaurants or different foods.

How frequently do you purchase products or services recommended by influencers
51 responses

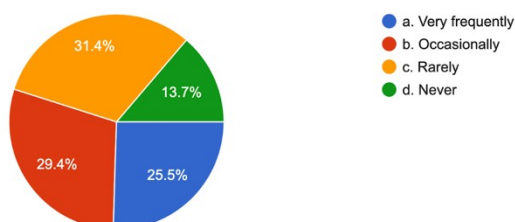


Figure 8. Purchasing Frequency percentage result

Figure 8 represents the frequency of the individuals purchasing different products or services that influencers recommend is vital to our research since it shows how impactful or not, they are to the buying behavior. The options ranged from “very frequently” to “never” as to measure how frequently they buy. The results show that many people follow influencers, but not all purchase from what they offer or show on screen. 31.4% of the respondents rarely purchase from influencers and 29.4% occasionally purchase. This shows that females do watch and follow up, but they are not easily influenced with what they see just because someone they follow talked about or said it was a good purchase.

What factors influence your decision to buy products or services recommended by influencers
(Select all that apply)

51 responses

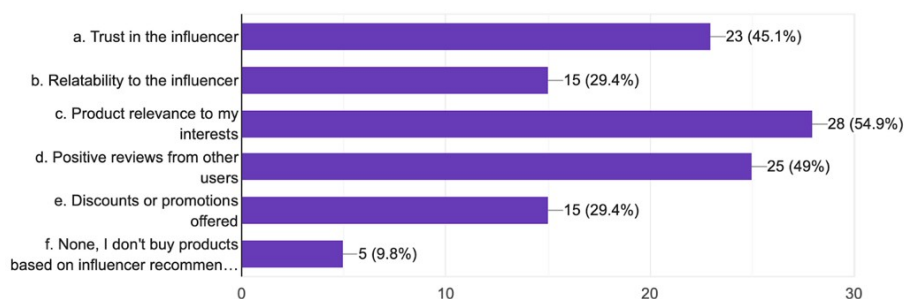


Figure 9. Decision influence percentage result

Figure 9 shows the different factors that somehow push the individual to purchase the product or service that influencer recommends range from having trust in the influencer, their relatability, the discounts they offer, or none of the factors could influence the behavior. The highest percentage factor that affects buying the displayed product by the influencers is “product relevance to my interest” with 54.9% , meaning that females care so much on how this product or service comes along with what they like or are interested about. Also, 49% of the respondents look for the positive reviews from other people that purchased, that is a very important factor to look at before purchasing any product on the internet.

Have you ever made a purchase solely based on an influencer's recommendation

51 responses

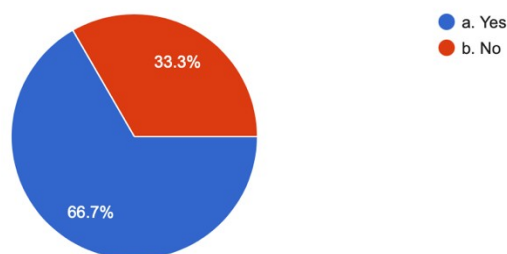


Figure 10. Purchasing decision percentage result

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Figure 10 aims to assess the extent of which influencers can influence their followers solely by recommending the product. 66.7% of the respondents chose “Yes” while the rest 33.3% chose “No”. This indicates that the majority of the respondents can get influenced to purchase a product if the influencer they follow recommends it. This also suggests that the level of influence influencers have is considered high.

How would you rate the credibility of influencers in relation to product recommendations

51 responses

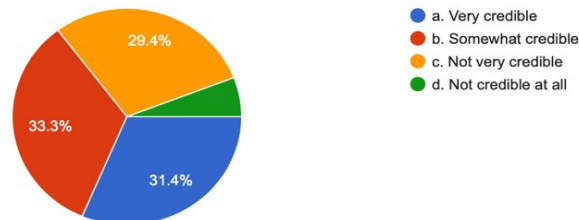


Figure 11. Rating credibility of influencers

Figure 11 shows that 33.3% of the participants chose “Somewhat credible”, 31.4% chose “Very credible”, 29.4% chose “Not very credible”, while only 5.9% chose “Not credible at all”. This suggests that the majority of the sample thinks that influencers to some degree have credibility, while only a small portion believes that influencers have no credibility at all. This indicates that influencers have a strong ability to significantly impact on their followers’ buying decisions.

Do you believe that influencers actually use the products they promote.

51 responses

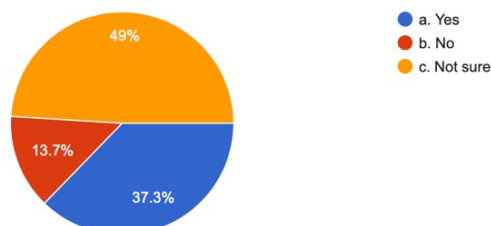


Figure 12. Trusting influencers or not percentage results

Figure 12 shows 49% of the participants chose “Not sure” and 13.7% chose “No” which makes up most of the respondents. This shows that the majority are not sure whether their influencers actually use the products they advertise. 37.3% chose “Yes” which is a relatively significant portion of the sample who believe that influencers in fact use the products they promote.

How do you assess the authenticity of influencer content

51 responses

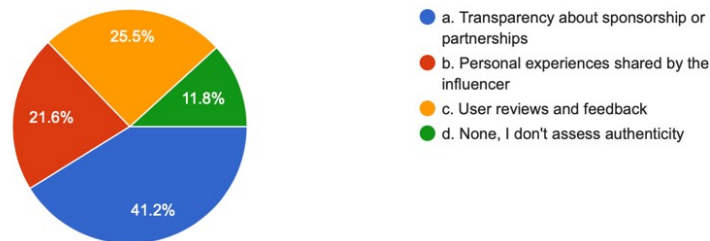


Figure 13. Assessing Authenticity

Figure 13 presents 41.2% of respondents say “Transparency about sponsorship or partnerships” which indicates that honesty plays a major role in gaining the followers' trust for the influencers. 25.5% chose “User reviews and feedback” which indicates that reputation is an important role.

Do you think Saudi influencers accurately reflect female consumers' interests and preferences

56 responses

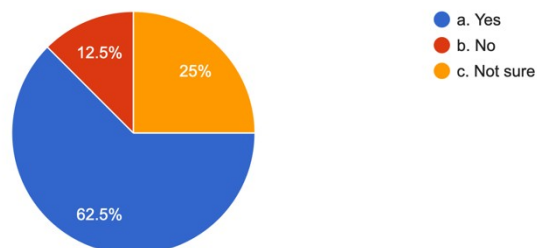


Figure 14. Reflection of accuracy of influencer percentage results

Figure 14 shows that there are different perspectives among the female's opinions. 62.5% of the responses answered affirmatively, and 12.5% disagreed, and a notable 12.5% are uncertain which highlights the diversity of opinions on this matter.

Have you ever been disappointed with a product or service you purchased based on an influencer's recommendation
54 responses

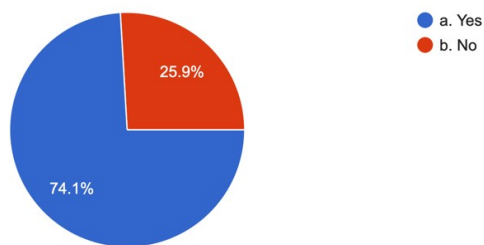


Figure 15.

Disappointment percentage level

Figure 15 reported that many respondents, 74.1%, being disappointed with a product or service purchased. This suggests that consumers are less satisfied with the effectiveness of products approved by influencers. In contrast, 25.9% of respondents indicated that they had experienced no such disappointment.

How do you think the influencer industry in Saudi Arabia will evolve over the next five years
56 responses

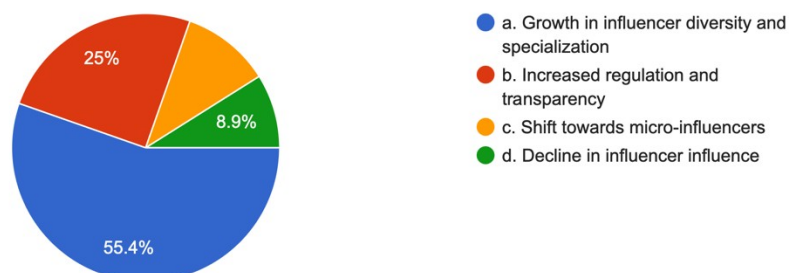


Figure 16. Evolvement of Influencer industry

Figure 16 shows the majority (55.4%) say growth in influencer diversity and specialization. A 25% foresee increased regulation and transparency. A small percentage (8.9%) predict a decline in the influencer's influence. These trends suggest dynamic changes ahead for the industry.

How do you believe influencer marketing has affected traditional advertising methods in Saudi Arabia
56 responses

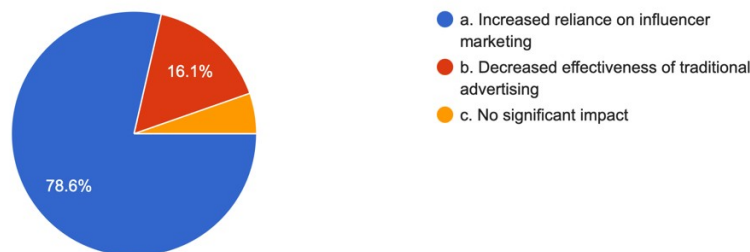


Figure 17. Relation of influencer marketing and traditional advertising

Figure 17 shows that 78.6% of participants think that influencer marketing has become more important. While 16.1% believe that traditional advertising techniques are less effective, and most respondents acknowledge the revolutionary effect of influencer marketing on regional advertising methods.

5. Findings:

SMIs have grown in number in Saudi Arabia, with many different influencers that market their lifestyles, travel, beauty, fashion, fitness, music, and health. Our research has shown some significant conclusions about the dynamics of influencer marketing in the Kingdom of Saudi

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Arabia.

A complement of SMIs is their influence on female consumers of Saudi Arabia, where SMIs considerably influence their decisions to buy or associate with. Influencers' way of life and endorsements influence their followers to purchase something, try new habits, and influence their followers through the way of living. A comprehensive questionnaire was developed during this research; it entailed 21 questions from different scales, with Likert and open-ended questions, and 50 female respondents that aimed to collect information on influencer marketing in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia.

Age Demographics

The survey showed that 92% of the respondents were 18-24 years old Singles, which reflects the demographic segment directly influenced by social media and targeted through influencer marketing.

Marital Status

Moreover, the analysis of marital status confirms valuable insights into the demographic information that can be used in market segmentation. This aspect is critical, considering that the identified segment has a high share among female consumers considering purchasing behavior within KSA.

Geographical Distribution

In addition, the regional distribution highlighted two highest-impact cities: Jeddah and Riyadh. Therefore, it indicates that the considered image has numerous identified segments with various dynamics within the market.

MGT490SPRING 2024 Preferred Social Media Platforms

Instagram has become the platform, for female participants closely followed by Snapchat and TikTok. This emphasizes the importance for marketers to concentrate their influencer marketing efforts on these platforms to connect effectively with their target audience.

Following Influencers

A large majority (90%) of participants mentioned that they follow influencers on media indicating the significant role influencers play in influencing consumer preferences and buying decisions.

Influencer Impact on Purchasing Behavior

The research showed that most respondents (90%) who follow influencers on media have access to types of content such as product endorsements and exclusive deals. This demonstrates the impact of influencers in shaping consumer trends and purchasing decisions as followers keep up with industry advancements and promotional opportunities.

Cultural Context and Consumer Engagement

The cultural context of Saudi Arabia enhances the impact of influencers, who mediate between brands and consumers in a largely conservative society. However, the country has become more approachable to the general public over the past ten years. This trend began in 2018 when Saudi women were given the opportunity to drive. The country's tourism industry has benefited from

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the country's increased number of cities, infrastructure, and events, which have contributed to the country's cultural landscape by exposing women to greater freedom, accessibility, and inspiration to pursue further knowledge and investigation into the lifestyles they envision for themselves. Influencers boost audience engagement and trust by incorporating cultural values, customs, and promotions of all types in beauty, travel, music, local tourism, and fitness into their content.

Authenticity and Relatability

Building trust with their audience through sincere communication and content is essential for influencers to maintain their relevance and hold their audience's attention. Influencers boost audience engagement and trust by incorporating cultural values, customs, and promotions of all types in beauty, travel, music, local tourism, and fitness into their content.

Collaboration with Brands

Influencers and brands work together to sway the perceptions and purchasing decisions of people. When they see product placements, brand collaborations, and sponsored content, they feel validated and authorized, which influences their purchasing decision.

6. Conclusion:

This study was conducted to assess the impact of Saudi Arabian customers' decisions to buy products on social media influencers. The main conclusions of this study demonstrated how social media influencers' endorsements and brand ads greatly affect consumers' decisions to

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buy. Furthermore, the results indicate that these consumers place a higher value on celebrity endorsements than on product quality and price. Furthermore, the majority of respondents thought that the corporations primarily leveraged celebrity endorsements to boost sales and profits. Therefore, it can be said that a celebrity's attractiveness, how they utilize a product, their good public perception, and the fact that they are perceived as celebrities all have a significant impact on consumers' decisions to buy products.

Our findings highlight the strong impact of social media influencers (SMIs) on consumer behavior in the Kingdom, notably in terms of purchase decisions and online impulsive buying. Saudi Arabia's cultural context enhances the impact of SMIs, who serve as cross-betweeners for organizations and customers in a international in which advertising and marketing is restrained. Customers respect recommendations from reliable influencers, therefore authenticity and relatability appear to be critical elements influencing the success of influencer advertising and marketing campaigns. Influencer and corporate cooperation increases purchaser validation and agree with, which impacts purchase decisions.

6.1 Future research

Further researches will need to focus more on longitudinal studies in order to assess changes in the buying behavior over time, segmentations analysis to understand how various segments of female buyers respond to the influencer marketing, content analysis to prove which types of content are the best ones to use in advertising and marketing campaign focusing on females in

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Saudi Arabia , studies on how influencers and their It can involve research that follows pre-defined experimental research designs to test the potential causality between exposure to influencer content and consumer behaviour.

6.2 Recommendations

Various strategies can be used to ensure using influencer marketing targeting female consumers in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia (KSA) sells. First, the campaigns should be tailored depending on the demographics and cultural differences that define the varied makeup of people living in a country in question. Vulnerability is critical for the trust to be achieved with the Saudi women; therefore honest and vulnerable influencer collaborations are required. It is crucial to choose social media platforms wisely as the campaigns should operate on platforms that are popular and their targeted audience in KSA is active on every day. Moreover, the media should be focused on utilizing engagement methods so that the viewers and the audiences can be involved and participate in the content. Finally, adhering to the ethics that prohibit the Saudi market from biased or controversial campaigns is critical for preserving credibility and respect within the Saudi market.

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The research question is how influencers affect the female buying behavior in KSA.

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